“Nothing Is Wrong. How Do We Even Bring This Up?”

Eight questions families ask about care wishes, answered plainly, and when to take yours to a professional.

Your wife is independent and nothing has changed. You'd still like to know what she would want if it ever did, and you're not sure how a family talks about that. These are the questions that come up most, answered in general terms.

None of the answers is about your wife in particular. Where a question needs someone who knows her, the answer says who to ask.

1 She's independent and nothing is wrong. Is there anything to talk about yet?

There's nothing to decide, and that is what makes it a comfortable time to talk. The National Institute on Aging says a conversation about what care might be wanted in the future is most productive when there is not an emergency. The subject isn't a move or a service. It's what she enjoys about her life now and would want to keep. [1]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** something about her health is on your mind. That's a question for her doctor, and it's a separate one from this conversation.

2 How should we begin this conversation?

Ask her permission first, and begin with everyday life rather than anything that sounds like a plan. The National Institute on Aging suggests starting simple. AARP's planning guide for families suggests looking for an opening, such as an article you've read or something you saw on the news. The Conversation Project lists the kitchen table, the car and a walk among the places these talks happen. [2] [3] [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you'd like someone else to help open the subject. The National Institute on Aging notes that some people are more comfortable talking with a doctor or someone in their spiritual community.

3 What if she doesn't want to talk about it?

Then she doesn't, for now, and “not today” is an answer to respect. AARP's guide says that if a first conversation doesn't go well, you can try again, and start small with just one part of what's on your mind. It also says you may be surprised to find she has been meaning to have the talk, too. [3]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** she would rather talk it over with someone outside the family. Who that is, is hers to choose.

4 How do we find out what she'd want to keep?

Ask about ordinary days. One question the Conversation Project's starter guide asks is “What does a good day look like for you?” For more detail, a federal toolkit on person-centered thinking suggests asking a person to walk through a typical weekday and a typical weekend day. Write down her answers in her own words, and keep your guesses on a separate line. [4] [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you'd like her to be asked by someone other than family. Your care consultant asks her directly what is important to her.

5 After all these years, don't I already know what she wants?

You know a great deal, and some of it will turn out to be exactly right. The National Institute on Aging says the best way to know what someone needs is to ask them directly, and the Conversation Project observes that we sometimes think others know how we feel when they don't. Ask anyway, and write what she says beside what you expected. [6] [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** what she says and what the family expected turn out to differ, and you'd like help keeping the two straight. Your care consultant keeps her wishes separate from the family's.

6 Should the kids be part of this, and when?

That's partly hers to say. The Institute for Healthcare Improvement tells care teams to begin by asking the person whether they would like to talk and how involved they want others to be. One way to do it is a first conversation between the two of you, with the kids brought in afterward. When the family does sit down together, the Family Caregiver Alliance says a successful family meeting gives everyone a chance to be heard. [7] [8]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the family has trouble talking together. The Family Caregiver Alliance says it often helps to invite a neutral outside facilitator, and names social workers and ministers among the people who can facilitate or refer you to someone who does.

7 What should the family understand about its own limits?

That everyone has them, and that saying so is a kindness. The National Institute on Aging says no one can be expected to do everything, and asks people to be realistic about how much they can do and what they are willing to do. AARP's guide suggests each family member consider what they are prepared and not prepared to do. Ask each of the kids what they could really offer, how often, and what it depends on, and write down the answer they give. [1] [3]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the family wants help understanding what it can realistically contribute. That is part of what your care consultant helps a family work out.

8 Does this have to end with a plan?

No. It ends with a page: what she wants to keep, what each of you could honestly offer, and the questions nobody can answer yet. The Conversation Project says there's no need to say everything that matters in one conversation; you can start talking, then keep talking. Agree with her when you'll look at the page again. [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** a question on your list is medical or legal. Medical questions go to her doctor and legal ones to an attorney. This guide answers neither.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer any question about your wife herself, and it doesn't say what your family should decide. Anything about her health belongs with her doctor. Anything about her wishes belongs with her.

Ready for the next step?

You have plain answers to the general questions. The care interview is where the questions become about your wife: when you're both ready, it walks you through her situation area by area and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities
2. National Institute on Aging, Advance Care Planning and Health Care Decisions: Tips for Caregivers and Families
3. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
4. The Conversation Project (Institute for Healthcare Improvement), Your Conversation Starter Guide: How to talk about what matters to you and have a say in your health care
5. Administration for Community Living (National Center on Advancing Person-Centered Practices and Systems), Office of Healthcare Information and Counseling Person-Centered Thinking Toolkit
6. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?
7. Institute for Healthcare Improvement (Age-Friendly Health Systems, with The John A. Hartford Foundation), “What Matters” to Older Adults? A Toolkit for Health Systems to Design Better Care with Older Adults
8. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting